“MUSIC HAS NO CASTE.”

Bismillah Khan was born in Bihar, into a family of court musicians. Khan was taught to play the shehnai by his uncle Ali Baksh, a musician who played at the Vishwanath temple in Varanasi. Typically played only at religious ceremonial occasions or weddings, Khan elevated the shehnai to an instrument played simply for aesthetic pleasure, like the veena or the tabla. His inventiveness changed perceptions of how the shehnai could be played and the kind of music it could be made to produce. And, as a devout Muslim who performed frequently at Hindu ceremonies and temples, he epitomized India’s syncretic history and religious pluralism.

JAGDISH SWAMINATHAN

1928–1994



Jagdish Swaminathan was a journalist, critic and talented painter. In his work, he sought to break free of existing approaches to painting, arguing instead that art should more truly represent the world through the use of colours and shapes. He grew to be well-respected in the Indian art world, and helped establish Bharat Bhavan in Bhopal, an arts institution funded by the government of Madhya Pradesh. During his tenure as director of the